Two Reflections

GUIDED REFLECTION: SELF-FORGIVENESS SCAN

Even when we are not overtly at war with ourselves, we often move through the day judging ourselves for the ways we feel we are falling short. This practice brings our self-judgments into awareness so they can be seen and released. It's an especially cleansing way to end the day. Try it when you are lying in bed before you go to sleep.

Take some moments to become still and to relax any obvious areas of tension. Then take a few long, slow breaths to help you arrive fully in your body.

Now ask yourself, "Is there anything between me and being at home with myself?" (Feel free to change the wording in any way that helps you identify the presence of self-blame.) Then pause and see what comes up in your body and mind. What stories of wrongdoing have you been telling yourself? Stories of letting others down, of performing poorly at work, of not meeting your standards as a parent, partner, friend, or human being.

If something arises, simply acknowledge it and offer it forgiveness. You might gently place your hand on your heart and whisper, "Forgiven, forgiven," or "It's okay." Recall your intention not to push yourself out of your own heart. Then inquire again: Is there anything else you're holding against yourself? Continue in this way until you've identified whatever self-judgments you've been carrying. End the scan by offering yourself a prayer or blessing, a wish for your own peace of heart and mind.

GUIDED REFLECTION: ENDING THE WAR WITH YOURSELF

Often our deepest suffering is the sense that something we have done—something about us—is fundamentally wrong and unacceptable. Finding a way to make peace with our human imperfections is the ground of all healing.

Find a comfortable sitting position and take a few moments to relax obvious areas of tension in your body. Connect with your intention to open your heart to your own being. Then bring to mind some aspect of yourself that has felt unforgivable. Perhaps you can't forgive yourself for being a judgmental and controlling person, or for how you have hurt others. You might not be able to forgive how you are ruining your life with an addictive behavior. You might feel disgust for your mental obsession. What feels so wrong or bad about your unforgivable behavior, emotion, or way of thinking? Allow yourself to feel the aversion that you have toward yourself.

Now explore more deeply what is driving this unacceptable part of you. If you are addicted to food, nicotine, or alcohol, ask what needs you are trying to satisfy. What fears are you trying to soothe? When you are judging others, are you feeling fearful yourself?

If you have wounded another person, did you act out of hurt and insecurity? Out of the need to feel powerful or safe? Look at yourself and your vulnerability through the eyes of the most understanding and loving friend, relative, or deity.

As you become aware of these underlying wants and fears, allow yourself to feel them directly in your body, heart, and mind. Even though you dislike the behaviors, try to hold this underlying vulnerability with compassion. Placing your hand on your heart, send a sincere message of

self-compassion directly to the places of fear and unmet needs—to the pain that has given rise to what feels unforgivable. You might mentally whisper, "I see how I've caused myself suffering, and I forgive myself now." Or you might simply offer yourself the words, "Forgiven, forgiven."

Meet whatever arises—fear or judgment, shame or grief—with the message of forgiveness. Even resistance to forgiving can be met with, "Forgiven, forgiven." You might call on the presence of someone you consider to be deeply loving and understanding, and feel his or her compassion flowing into you, supporting you. Discover what happens when you bring an unconditionally forgiving heart to the parts of you that are wounded and vulnerable.

When you feel unable to forgive yourself: You might believe you don't deserve to be forgiven or fear that if you forgive yourself, you'll just do the same thing again. Maybe you're afraid that if you really open yourself to forgiveness, you'll come face to face with some intolerable truth. If these doubts and fears arise, acknowledge and accept them with compassion. Then say to yourself, "It is my intention to forgive myself when I am able." Your intention to forgive is the seed of forgiveness—this willingness will gradually relax and open your heart.

—Meditations from *True Refuge* by Tara Brach

Self-Forgiveness

This exercise follows the guided practice "Ending the War with Yourself."

JOURNAL

What insights, openings or challenges emerged in the guided meditation? (5 minutes)

DYADS

Share about your experience of the guided meditation, drawing on your journal if that's helpful. (5 minutes each)

OPEN DIALOGUE

When teaching about self-forgiveness, what do you feel is most important to convey? What questions do you have about self-forgiveness, and/or guiding others in self-forgiveness practice? (10 minutes)